vague the public position is of China, the more likely it is that the real position is harder and less flexible.

The Chinese have a fear of being the 'only one standing'. This happens once in a while. Such a situation affects their image, which is something they have carefully nurtured over the years. The claim that there is no 'consensus' is something that the Chinese work on very hard if they want to stall anything in multilateral bodies. However, once in a while, they do find themselves alone, as they did on the listing of Masood Azhar in 2019.

In such cases, the Chinese interlocutor will make strenuous efforts to persuade the Indian side that this is not a bilateral issue, but a multilateral one. When it is a question concerning China and where they need support from India, they will never accept a similar claim by India that the issue is multilateral and not bilateral. On the contrary, the Chinese side will make it clear that it considers the Indian standpoint in the bilateral perspective, and that a stand taken by India that is contrary to China's interests will have bilateral repercussions. However, China does not extend the same principle to India when the shoe is on the other foot. Hence, it is important to firmly reject this idea and make it clear that the way China votes or speaks on issues of importance to India in multilateral platforms is always a bilateral issue.

Post-Negotiation

After any negotiation or meeting is concluded, the Chinese will come up to the Indian interlocutor to suggest that both sides 'coordinate' their public positions. The idea is to manage the narrative of the opposite side. This is to ensure that the image that China projects is not harmed in any way and there will be no surprises thrown at them by the other side in public.